

to be maintained, establishing the Nuclear Liability Fund, requiring operators to obtain adequate insurance or other financial security for nuclear liability, and developing standard-form contracts to govern operators' rights of recourse against suppliers.

The effectiveness of the Act hinges on the efficacy of its institutions and the robustness of its processes. The immediate priority is therefore the constitution of a credible regulatory ecosystem, including the appointment of the Chairperson and Members of the regulatory board with the requisite qualifications and independence safeguards; notifica-

tion of qualifications, tenure and service conditions across adjudicatory bodies; definition of the board's financial and administrative powers; and development of institutional capabilities in contract management for complex, long-term PPP or hybrid structures. This must be anchored in a clear national policy direction that aligns nuclear expansion with India's broader energy and climate strategy.

India must build and constantly upskill a skilled workforce and institutional capacity across the value chain. Availability of specialised human capital to design, construct, operate, regulate and oversee facilities

will be critical. Rules must therefore prescribe competency standards, accreditation frameworks, continuous training requirements and a strong safety culture, including incident reporting and periodic audits.

Several cross-cutting enablers must be put in place. These include rules governing mining and resource control, directions on patent applications involving sensitive nuclear technologies, confidentiality and security measures to safeguard restricted information, and detailed claims and compensation procedures for nuclear damage.

Each of these elements address specific risk and value dimensions of nuclear energy and must be operationalised in tandem.

ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA



THE ROAD AHEAD

The implementation challenge is primarily one of sequencing and coordination across these elements.

A phased and consultative approach will be critical. Early prioritisation of safety regulations, licensing frameworks and institutional appointments can create momentum, followed by financial and policy measures to deepen participation.

Equally important will be stakeholder engagement—particularly with civil society in plant locations, industry, insurers and international partners—to ensure that the framework is both robust and pragmatic.

The Act provides a comprehensive legislative foundation for India's nuclear energy ambitions. However, its success will depend on the timely and coherent execution of an extensive rule-making and policy agenda. The next phase is therefore about building a functioning, credible and investible nuclear ecosystem. The real work has just begun. **BT**

Views are personal